

Relationship-Building for Managers

You've probably noticed today's newer team members think about work and respond to leadership differently from you. Here's how to build a relationship that inspires their best.



Invest before you withdraw

Every interaction is a deposit or a withdrawal from a running account. Before you make a hard ask, make sure you've made enough deposits to absorb it. Small, frequent deposits compound.



Seen, Valued, Trusted

An action counts as a deposit only if it makes the person feel:

Seen as a person, not just labor,

Valued for their contribution, or

Trusted with responsibility and judgment

A deposit isn't the same as "being nice." Hollow praise can land as patronizing. Honest, specific critique can land as a deposit.



Tough on Results, Tender on People

You don't have to lower your standards.

Demand excellence on the work; treat the person doing it like a person.

TRIP: Making a Difficult Ask

Sometimes you have to make a tough ask — a late night, weekend work, etc. The way you ask shapes how it's received. Here's a framework for asking well.

T

Thank them

It goes a long way.

R

Give a reason

Why are you asking for this, and why now?

I

Acknowledge the impact

Show that you see what this costs them.

P

Include praise

Affirm what makes them right for this ask.

Example

"I know this might mess up your evening (I), but the client moved up their deadline and it took me by surprise (R). I'll need that memo tonight. Coming to you with this because I know you have the skills to handle this the right way (P). Thanks for your help (T)."

The Recognition Ladder

When someone on your team does great work, the way you recognize it shapes how it's received. Here's a four-rung ladder, ordered from low effort to high effort.

- 1 — Praise privately**
A short message, a quick word in the hallway, a thank-you at the end of a call.
Takes 30 seconds.
- 2 — Praise publicly**
Mention them in a meeting, an email thread, a Teams channel, an all-hands.
Skip this if others contributed comparably - or make sure to name them too.
- 3 — Praise Upward**
Speak well of them to someone whose opinion carries weight: their boss, a senior leader, a client. (*Note: for this to land as a deposit, the team member has to know it happened.*)
- 4 — Entrust with responsibility**
Give them a bigger piece: lead a project, run a meeting, own a deliverable.
Your trust is the highest form of recognition.

Check the fit

Higher rungs aren't always better. An introvert may dread public praise. Someone already overloaded may hear "more responsibility" as punishment. Match the move to the person.

Small Moves that Build Big Relationships

Strong working relationships are built through consistent, small moves. **The Three “In”s** are a framework for those moves, ordered from low effort to high effort.

1 Introduction

Connect them to someone valuable. “I want to get you on X’s radar.”

2 Invitation

Invite them to something valuable - a client call, a strategy meeting, a lunch.

3 Interest

Take an interest in how they’re doing. “How are you holding up?” in the middle of a hard week.

Using the Three “Ins”

Interest is the baseline; use it regularly. **Introduction** and **Invitation** are situational; deploy when the opportunity arises.

Avoiding Stress Spillover

It's easy to let stress or frustration bleed into an email or a comment in a meeting. This practice keeps that from happening.

The Rule

1 Before Speaking, 3 Before Sending

When you feel stressed, frustrated, or keyed up:

- ✓ Take **one breath** before speaking.
- ✓ Take **three breaths** before sending an email.

Why one vs. three?

In a live conversation, a one-breath pause is discreet. Three might seem odd.

With email, you have privacy to take longer. Plus, email leaves a record, so it's worth taking the extra time.